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Culture (OWC): [Bemba \(FQ05\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1930-1934

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Zambia

Section Title(S)

The Cooking Team. • The Value of the Cooking Team.

The men's group based on the matrilocal system is smaller and less closely knit. Between the sons-in-law attached to one household there is a feeling of close friendship and familiarity. These young men eat and work together, and the term *Ciufi munandi*, 'the man who married with me', or into the same family, is one of affection and good fellowship. There are no taboos between a man and his wife's sisters. He laughs and jokes with them because he may one day marry them, and he works in their gardens if they need help. But the young husbands often come from different villages and clans, and will want, as soon as they can, to have gardens of their own and perhaps to take their wives back to their villages. In the same way there may be co-operation from time to time between an old man and one of his own young kinsmen, such as his grandson or maternal nephew, but these also come and go, marry in other villages, and get work with Europeans. This group does not remain in close association throughout life as do the women of the matrilocal group, whether the latter remain in the same village or not. ¹ This fact has important bearings at the present time. Through the unit of male labour is often non-existent, with the absence of so many of the men at the mines, the domestic and gardening economy of the women remains for the most part intact, and there seems no doubt that women deserted for months or even years by their husbands are more happily placed in a matrilocal community than in a patrilocal one. ²

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The Value of the Cooking Team.

The practical results of this type of domestic economics should be considered, since it is apparently one that is likely to change  132 in the future. Is there any advantage, economic or otherwise, in this particular system of joint labour? To share food from the same dish is certainly more economical than preparing separate portions. There is always enough, the Bemba women say, if you eat out of one basket.¹ This is ensured by the custom of grouping of men and of women and children at meals.

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One legal case concerned a young married woman, one of six sisters, real or classificatory, who had lived in the same village and worked s happily together that when her husband removed her to his own village after the necessary years of service, she could not bear to live away from her family. The contrast between the cheerful female group in her own village and her relative isolation in her husband's community was too great. She ran back home for the third time during my stay at the village (Pambalasa, 1930). Divorce was the final result. Such a case is an extreme instance of the female solidarity which is so marked in a matrilineal tribe of this kind.

Dr. Margaret Read confirms this on the basis of a comparative study between the patrilineal Ngoni and the matrilineal Chewa of Nyasaland.

It will be seen (pp. 139, 41, 70) how housewives give their kinswomen grain to grind when food is plentiful, a small portion of flour when it is less so, and an invitation to share their dish when it is really scarce.

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